Ethical Lens: The Common Good

AI Example

Whose City, Whose Routes?

Imagine a mid-sized city uses AI to optimize its bus system. The algorithms recommend cuts to low-ridership routes. Although just focusing on ridership, the cuts mostly impact busses that largely serve the elderly and low-income neighborhoods.

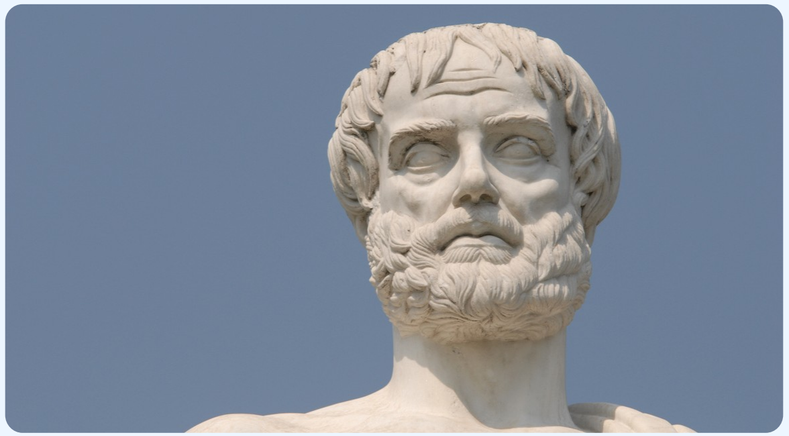
Multiple Stakeholders, Multiple Values

- Environmentalists support the change for reducing CO2 emissions.
- Advocates for the elderly and low-income people oppose it for hurting vulnerable populations. Some of these residents argue the city is no longer “theirs.”
- Technocrats argue the AI is neutral and data-driven.

Negotiating the Common Good

In a pluralistic society, the common good must be negotiated, not assumed. It demands inclusive deliberation—not just data, but dialogue—and insists public systems should reflect a shared moral vision, not just technical optimization.

Defining the Common Good



Ancient Origins

Concept originated over 2000 years ago in writings of Plato, Aristotle, and Cicero.

Modern Interpretation

The political philosopher John Rawls defined the common good as: “certain general conditions that are...equally to everyone’s advantage.”

Catholic Tradition

“The sum of those conditions of social life which allow social groups and their individual members relatively thorough and ready access to their own fulfillment.”

Some Components of the Common Good

Public Health

Accessible and affordable healthcare system.

Justice System

Fair legal and political framework.

Environment

Unpolluted natural surroundings.

Economy

Flourishing economic system.

Collective Effort and Shared Benefits

Cooperative Efforts

Establishing and maintaining the common good requires collective action from citizens. For example, you can’t keep a public park clean unless everyone works together to keep it litter-free.

Universal Access

The common good provides benefits that all members of society can access and enjoy, such as clean air or an unpolluted environment.

Obstacles to Achieving the Common Good

Pluralism

In a pluralistic society, differing ideas about what constitutes “the good life” can make it challenging, if not impossible, to find a unified vision of the common good.

Free-Rider Problem

Individuals can try to benefit from common good projects without contributing their fair share.

Individualism

Cultural emphasis on personal freedom and rights can lead people to not want to make sacrifices for others.

Unequal Burdens

Some common goods projects can result in disproportionate costs for certain groups or individuals, and thus unequal sharing of burdens.